

for Sony and the gaming industry. Nintendo also entered the race with 'Nintendo 64' and Super Mario 64, showcasing one of the most beautiful gaming experience of the time. Sega launched Saturn, which suffered from a number of development issues. The device was well received in Japan and even though it went on to become the company's most successful product in the country, it didn't create the same splash elsewhere and couldn't match Sony and Nintendo's success. Somewhere along the line it also paved way for the beginning of the end of a company that had been ruling the console industry for years. Let's look at what changed.

Key improvements

Until 4th generation, most consoles used a cartridge based system. The last major home console to use a cartridge based system was the 5th Generation Nintendo 64. Nintendo's initial plans involved a console with a CD-ROM in partnership with Sony. This deal was scrapped due to a number of reasons and pushed Sony into making its own console instead while Nintendo planned to launch its console with a CD-ROM manufactured by Philips. But that deal also fell through and they ended up launching it with a cartridge based system only justifying its use on shorter load times of cartridges compared to CD-ROM.

But Compact Disc had arrived on the scene and it was here to stay. Sony had developed the CD-ROM technology in collaboration with Philips and slowly but steadily had become a part of the home computing scene of the late 80s. Console makers also realized the advantages this medium offered over the older cartridge based system and started adopting the technology. Some of the advantages it had were

- A CD could hold 660 MB, much more than what a cartridge could hold. (A Nintendo 64 cartridge could hold around 64 MB of data.)
- CD ROMs were cheaper to manufacture, which meant less risk and loss for game developers.
- Also the companies sold CD ROMS at a lesser retail price compared to cartridges so as to compensate for cost of the expensive CD ROM Drives.

This shift led to a number of developments in the field. Now there was more space. Which meant more data which in turn led to more detailed and immersive games. Infact one of the most popular games of the time, Final Fantasy VII was supposed to be released on the Nintendo 64. But because of the storage limitation put up by the cartridge based system, it was ultimately launched on the PlayStation.